

Administration, Economy & Society under the Sultanate - Solved Practice Workbook

UPSC complete learning session | Foundation to advanced | Concepts, evidence, practice and answer writing

Medieval History 07

Administration, Economy & Society under the Sultanate | Cross-dynastic thematic synthesis | 1206-1526

Administration

- Sultan, offices, iqta, audit, army
- and intelligence changed across dynasties.
- Centralisation always relied on provincial and village intermediaries.

Economy

- Agrarian surplus, towns, currency, trade, crafts and technology
- formed a military-fiscal economy.
- Growth and coercion coexisted.

Society

- Nobles, peasants, artisans, merchants, ulama, Sufis, slaves
- and women experienced rule unevenly.
- Avoid static binaries.

How to read the topic

Best exam formula: Persianate military-fiscal state at the apex
-> negotiated sovereignty below -> regional and social unevenness throughout. Read court chroniclers, coins, inscriptions, architecture and later textbooks separately before synthesising.

Topic-specific cover: state formation, agrarian surplus, towns, law and society change together.

Original deterministic study visual; labels are explanatory, not textual quotations.

Source order: repository knowledge -> official current linkage -> clearly marked analysis. No fabricated PYQs or statistics.

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Major learning parts and meaningful subtopics are listed in document order. Page numbers are generated from the final PDF layout; PDF bookmarks mirror the same hierarchy.

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BASIC MCQS / REMEDIATION

Learning MCQ 01

Question: What is the safest opening description of Topic 07?

- A. It studies institutions as changing, negotiated and regionally uneven across the Sultanate rather than repeating ruler biographies.
- B. It treats the Delhi Sultanate as a finished modern bureaucracy from 1206 onward.
- C. It replaces administration with only art and architecture.
- D. It is a single-reign summary of Alauddin's reforms.

Answer: A.

Explanation: The topic is cross-dynastic and thematic; reduction to one ruler or one administrative diagram is exactly the trap to avoid.

Learning MCQ 02

Question: Which statement best captures Sultanate state formation?

- A. Persianate symbols replaced all local institutions overnight.
- B. Military conquest created openings, but durable rule depended on court forms, local intermediaries and inherited agrarian structures.
- C. Once Delhi won a battle, countryside administration became automatic.
- D. State formation was purely urban and detached from villages.

Answer: B.

Explanation: The strongest answer links cavalry and forts to revenue, local collaboration and social continuities.

Learning MCQ 03

Question: How should caliphal recognition be interpreted in Sultanate answers?

- A. As irrelevant decorative theology with no political use.
- B. As proof that the caliph governed India directly.
- C. As symbolic recognition that could enhance standing but did not by itself create army, territory or revenue power.
- D. As a permanent legal chain preventing rulers from issuing their own regulations.

Answer: C.

Explanation: Iluttmish and later rulers used caliphal idiom, but practical sovereignty rested elsewhere.

Learning MCQ 04

Question: Which office statement is correct?

- A. The ariz was the empire's supreme sovereign judge.
- B. The Diwan-i-Insha permanently handled irrigation canals.
- C. The Diwan-i-Risalat had one universally fixed portfolio in every reign.
- D. The ariz or Diwan-i-Arz supervised the military department, but the sultan remained commander-in-chief.

Answer: D.

Explanation: This question tests against projecting later or unrelated portfolios onto Sultanate offices.

Learning MCQ 05

Question: What is the best way to describe iqta?

- A. A transferable fiscal-military assignment tied to service, administration and in-principle audit.
- B. A modern district with salaried bureaucracy only.
- C. A south Indian gold coin used in coastal trade.
- D. Absolute private ownership of land and peasants.

Answer: A.

Explanation: Iqta should be defined through claim, service and recall - not as private estate.

Learning MCQ 06

Question: Why must local administration be described cautiously?

- A. Because no local officials existed below the province.
- B. Because terms such as shiq, pargana, zamindar and qanungo do not have identical meaning or visibility across all Sultanate centuries.
- C. Because only Mughal sources discuss local society.
- D. Because villages were completely untouched by the state.

Answer: B.

Explanation: Chronology caution is essential in medieval administrative vocabulary.

Learning MCQ 07

Question: Which revenue statement is safest?

- A. Kharaj was only a symbolic tax and never a real burden.
- B. Firuz abolished all non-sharia fiscal categories everywhere permanently.
- C. Legal labels such as kharaj, jizya and zakat matter, but actual fiscal practice often merged, varied and depended on political circumstance.
- D. Jizya had the same practical meaning in every district from 1206 to 1526.

Answer: C.

Explanation: UPSC rewards the distinction between juristic vocabulary and working extraction.

Learning MCQ 08

Question: What drove Alauddin's dagh and chehra controls?

- A. A village self-government reform.
- B. A Lodi attempt to promote maritime trade.
- C. A project to spread paper currency.
- D. The need to supervise cavalry quality and salary claims within a military-fiscal system.

Answer: D.

Explanation: Horse branding and descriptive rolls belong to army control, not to Mughal-first mythology.

Learning MCQ 09

Question: What is the best reading of Sultanate justice?

- A. Sharia courts, royal regulations, kotwal policing and local custom coexisted in a plural and hierarchical order.
- B. Village panchayats disappeared entirely after 1206.
- C. Qazis governed non-Muslim communities in all matters without exception.
- D. Only one uniform civil code operated everywhere.

Answer: A.

Explanation: Judicial pluralism is one of Topic 07's safest high-value themes.

Learning MCQ 10

Question: Why is agrarian history central to Topic 07?

- A. Because military spending was independent of revenue and grain.
- B. Because peasant production and intermediary control financed the court, army and towns through surplus transfer.
- C. Because Sultanate economy was mainly based on overseas tribute only.
- D. Because towns had no relationship with villages.

Answer: B.

Explanation: A military-fiscal state cannot be explained without its agrarian base.

Learning MCQ 11

Question: How should monetisation be described?

- A. As irrelevant to trade because only gifts mattered.
- B. As paper money introduced permanently by Muhammad bin Tughlaq.
- C. As a real but uneven expansion of cash circuits, coin use and credit, not as a neat linear transition from barter to market modernity.
- D. As complete replacement of grain demand by cash in every region.

Answer: C.

Explanation: Tanka, jital, hundis and salary systems all matter, but unevenly.

Learning MCQ 12

Question: Which description of Sultanate urbanisation is safest?

- A. Every town was only a military cantonment with no commerce.
- B. The Sultanate had one single capital and no provincial cities.
- C. Urban growth ended long-distance trade.
- D. Towns grew through court demand, garrisons, trade, crafts and regional exchange, while still depending on rural surplus.

Answer: D.

Explanation: Urbanisation debate is strongest when tied to both demand and extraction.

Learning MCQ 13

Question: What is the best way to answer the 2023 technology PYQ?

- A. By linking devices and techniques to social effects on crafts, irrigation, construction, administration and hierarchy.
- B. By claiming all technology came fully formed from one foreign source.
- C. By listing inventions without saying who used them.
- D. By discussing only gunpowder and nothing else.

Answer: A.

Explanation: The question is social-history oriented, not a trivia list.

Learning MCQ 14

Question: How should Alauddin's market regulation be placed in the wider economy?

- A. As proof that ordinary markets ceased to exist forever.
- B. As an intense state intervention within a broader commercial world still run through merchants, banjaras, brokers and credit.
- C. As the beginning of a socialist planned economy.
- D. As a measure that removed all need for grain transport.

Answer: B.

Explanation: The market episode is important, but it should not swallow the whole economy.

Learning MCQ 15

Question: What is the safest description of Muslims as a social category under the Sultanate?

- A. Only foreign-born Muslims mattered in any occupation.
- B. The terms ashraf, ajlaf and arzal can be projected backward without caution.
- C. They were internally differentiated by ethnicity, status, occupation and origin; they were not one timeless homogeneous bloc.
- D. All Muslims formed a perfectly equal community from the outset.

Answer: C.

Explanation: Status language changed over time and must be used carefully.

Learning MCQ 16

Question: Which conversion statement is safest?

- A. Conversion happened only by the sword.
- B. No social or regional variation mattered.
- C. Conversion happened only by mystical preaching and never by politics.
- D. Conversion was multi-causal: patronage, mobility, local politics, devotional contact, frontier processes and belief all mattered in uneven ways.

Answer: D.

Explanation: This defeats the most common one-cause narratives.

Learning MCQ 17

Question: How should gender evidence be handled?

- A. By distinguishing elite prescription from practice and by noting class and regional variation in seclusion, property and ritual.
- B. By claiming women disappear entirely from the source record.
- C. By treating sati and jauhar as everyday universal institutions.
- D. By assuming all women everywhere observed the same purdah pattern.

Answer: A.

Explanation: The evidence is uneven, but not nonexistent; cautious layering is essential.

Learning MCQ 18

Question: What is the best closing line for a GS-I answer on Topic 07?

- A. The Sultanate economy was prosperous for every class in the same way.
- B. The Sultanate was centralising in aspiration, negotiated in practice, and socially uneven in effect.
- C. The Sultanate was either fully feudal or fully modern, with no middle ground.
- D. The Sultanate state can be understood entirely from one chronicle.

Answer: B.

Explanation: This verdict keeps institution, debate and social hierarchy together.

Original broad-coverage MCQs

Rotation check rule: This original broad-coverage sequence starts at **A** and rotates strictly through **B, C and D**.

Broad MCQ 01

Question: Which phrase most accurately describes the Delhi Sultanate?

- A. A society without villages or intermediaries.
- B. A timeless nation-state with fixed ministries.
- C. A Persianate military-fiscal state whose central claims depended on negotiation below.
- D. A purely spiritual caliphate run from Baghdad.

Answer: C.

Explanation: The best phrase joins ideology, coercion and agrarian mediation.

Broad MCQ 02

Question: Why is the phrase 'Persianate' useful in Topic 07?

- A. Because only Persian literature mattered in the Sultanate.
- B. Because all rulers were ethnically Persian.
- C. Because Persianate culture abolished local languages.
- D. Because it captures a transregional language-administrative culture that could include rulers and officials of varied origins.

Answer: D.

Explanation: The term is cultural-political, not ethnic.

Broad MCQ 03

Question: What made Delhi important beyond military conquest?

- A. Coinage, chancery, migrant scholars, court ritual and revenue coordination reinforced its centrality.
- B. It was the only town in north India.
- C. It mattered only after the Mughals.

- D. It had no link with monetisation.

Answer: A.

Explanation: Delhi became a nodal political and cultural centre, not just a fort.

Broad MCQ 04

Question: Which statement about succession under the Sultanate is safest?

- A. Village panchayats chose the sultan.
- B. Nomination, noble acceptance, military strength and household politics all shaped succession.
- C. Primogeniture operated without interruption.
- D. Caliphal appointment automatically settled succession.

Answer: B.

Explanation: This defeats simplistic dynastic assumptions.

Broad MCQ 05

Question: Why should Diwan-i-Risalat be handled cautiously?

- A. Because it was a Mughal-only innovation.
- B. Because the office certainly never existed.
- C. Because its exact portfolio is reconstructed differently by scholars and may shift across reigns.
- D. Because it only managed artillery.

Answer: C.

Explanation: Terminology caution itself is a mark of strong historical method.

Broad MCQ 06

Question: What was the political use of the barid network?

- A. It minted copper jitals.
- B. It managed Hindu temple endowments only.
- C. It replaced the military department entirely.
- D. It carried intelligence upward and helped rulers watch governors, nobles and markets.

Answer: D.

Explanation: Information was a technology of rule.

Broad MCQ 07

Question: Which social group is most directly linked to village headship in Topic 07's core evidence?

- A. Muqaddams and related local landed intermediaries.
- B. Caliphal envoys.
- C. Barids.
- D. Mir bakhshis.

Answer: A.

Explanation: Village headship belongs to local agrarian hierarchy.

Broad MCQ 08

Question: Why is iqta not equivalent to European feudalism?

- A. Because iqta had no connection at all with revenue.
- B. Because the Sultanate state's superior claim, transfer power and audit logic differ from a simple proprietary-vassal model.
- C. Because Europe had no cavalry.
- D. Because iqta was a maritime customs office.

Answer: B.

Explanation: The comparison is useful only when its limits are stated.

Broad MCQ 09

Question: What does khalisa most clearly indicate?

- A. A type of slave corps.
- B. A class of urban merchants.
- C. Revenue reserved for more direct crown collection and visibility.
- D. The village police post.

Answer: C.

Explanation: Khalisa is central to any discussion of Alauddin or crown finance.

Broad MCQ 10

Question: Which ruler most clearly combined price regulation with military horse inspection?

- A. Babur.
- B. Khizr Khan Sayyid.
- C. Raziya Sultan.
- D. Alauddin Khalji.

Answer: D.

Explanation: Daggh and chehra must be placed correctly.

Broad MCQ 11

Question: Which statement about Muhammad bin Tughlaq is safest for Topic 07?

- A. He pushed centralisation, cash demand and recruitment widening further than his predecessors, but strained compliance and trust.
- B. He abolished monetisation.
- C. He ruled only Delhi and Palam.
- D. He had no interest in caliphal legitimacy.

Answer: A.

Explanation: The strongest line explains ambition and breakdown together.

Broad MCQ 12

Question: Why does Firuz matter in Topic 07?

- A. He abandoned public works entirely.
- B. He softened audit, encouraged heredity, expanded canals and workshops, and sharpened some juristic markers such as separate jizya.
- C. He removed all slave institutions.
- D. He invented the iqta from nothing.

Answer: B.

Explanation: Firuz's regime altered both welfare and hierarchy.

Broad MCQ 13

Question: What is the safest reading of jizya under the Sultanate?

- A. It was absent from all Sultanate history.
- B. It was always completely separate from land demand from the first day.
- C. It mattered politically and symbolically, but it should not stand in for the totality of Hindu-Muslim social relations.
- D. It proves that all policy was only religious.

Answer: C.

Explanation: The tax has to be placed in a broader fiscal and political field.

Broad MCQ 14

Question: What best explains the growth of hundis?

- A. The replacement of silver coins by cowries in Delhi.
- B. A ban on merchant initiative.
- C. The end of road travel.
- D. Long-distance trade, credit needs and the work of money-changers and financiers across regions.

Answer: D.

Explanation: Hundis belong to commercial and financial integration.

Broad MCQ 15

Question: Which commodity cluster best captures long-distance Sultanate trade?

- A. Textiles outward; horses, high-grade cloth and select goods inward.
- B. Only war booty outward and nothing inward.
- C. Only rice and wheat outward from every region.
- D. Only temple icons and paper outward.

Answer: A.

Explanation: Textiles remained India's most important manufacturing strength.

Broad MCQ 16

Question: What is the safest claim about artisans under the Sultanate?

- A. They were all village serfs with no urban presence.
- B. They worked in towns and villages, in independent settings and in state-linked workshops, under unequal social conditions.
- C. They disappeared after market regulation.
- D. They were all state slaves.

Answer: B.

Explanation: Craft life was varied and often poorly documented.

Broad MCQ 17

Question: How should the spinning wheel be used in an answer?

- A. As proof that every household became prosperous.
- B. As a guaranteed twelfth-century Indian invention with exact first date.
- C. As evidence of technological diffusion and textile efficiency, with chronology caution and social-effect analysis.
- D. As irrelevant to cloth production.

Answer: C.

Explanation: Technology claims need both mechanism and caution.

Broad MCQ 18

Question: Why is the term 'urban revolution' debated?

- A. Because only European trade created Indian towns.
- B. Because no towns existed at all.
- C. Because the debate concerns only architecture.
- D. Because town growth, crafts and monetisation were real, yet they rested on coercive extraction and uneven benefit.

Answer: D.

Explanation: This is one of Topic 07's major historiographical axes.

Broad MCQ 19

Question: What is the safest interpretation of ashraf-ajlaf language?

- A. It signals social differentiation within Muslim society, but its use needs chronology and source caution.
- B. It is a fixed fourteenth-century bureaucratic census category everywhere.
- C. It replaces all regional and occupational distinctions.
- D. It proves perfect class equality among Muslims.

Answer: A.

Explanation: The labels are real and useful, but not timeless.

Broad MCQ 20

Question: Which statement best captures the position of Hindus under the Sultanate?

- A. No Hindu served any state function.
- B. They were not simply excluded: chiefs, peasants, merchants, soldiers, accountants and managers all remained important, amid conflict and hierarchy.
- C. All Hindus were treated identically across all reigns.
- D. Hindu society vanished from the countryside.

Answer: B.

Explanation: The strongest answer combines cooperation and coercion.

Broad MCQ 21

Question: Why is conversion a poor master-explanation for Sultanate society?

- A. Because conversions never happened.
- B. Because only rulers converted.
- C. Because social history also turns on landed power, towns, labour, language, courts, trade and everyday negotiation.
- D. Because conversions alone explain every town and market.

Answer: C.

Explanation: Conversion matters, but it is not the only explanatory engine.

Broad MCQ 22

Question: What is the best distinction between bandagan and wider slavery?

- A. Bandagan were Mughal revenue clerks.
- B. Bandagan were identical to all slaves in law and social effect.
- C. Bandagan were simply village tenants.
- D. Bandagan were elite household military slaves with training and office prospects, unlike most domestic or captive slaves.

Answer: D.

Explanation: This is a crucial conceptual distinction in Topic 07.

Broad MCQ 23

Question: How should purdah be described?

- A. As a stronger upper-class and courtly norm that spread unevenly; not as a universal practice for all women in all regions.
- B. As a Sultanate law imposed successfully on everyone.
- C. As absent from all medieval India.
- D. As identical among every caste and class.

Answer: A.

Explanation: Gender answers need class and region built in.

Broad MCQ 24

Question: Which statement about education is safest?

- A. Paper-making ended manuscript culture.
- B. Maktabas, madrasas, mosques, khanqahs, Sanskrit learning and practical multilingualism coexisted.
- C. Persian replaced every other language immediately.
- D. Only royal princes were educated.

Answer: B.

Explanation: Knowledge institutions were multiple, not singular.

Broad MCQ 25

Question: Why are Persian-knowing Hindus important for Topic 07?

- A. They prove caste disappeared.
- B. They were only nineteenth-century phenomena.
- C. They show that administrative culture could expand across community lines without erasing hierarchy.
- D. They prove Persian ceased to dominate administration.

Answer: C.

Explanation: Language competence created new service niches.

Broad MCQ 26

Question: Which statement about Sufis in Topic 07 is safest?

- A. Sufis alone ran Sultanate law courts.
- B. All Sufis were anti-state in every setting.
- C. Topic 07 must ignore Sufis completely.
- D. They matter here mainly as part of social interaction and political context, while full movement ownership belongs to Topic 10.

Answer: D.

Explanation: Boundary discipline is part of a strong package.

Broad MCQ 27

Question: How should temple destruction and patronage be framed in Topic 07?

- A. Episodes must be placed in political, military and local context rather than being flattened into a single civilisational formula.
- B. Every temple was always protected.
- C. Every temple was always destroyed.
- D. The issue is irrelevant to social history.

Answer: A.

Explanation: This avoids communal simplification while remaining evidence-led.

Broad MCQ 28

Question: What is the strongest way to read Barani?

- A. As a perfectly neutral census reporter.
- B. As indispensable for elite ideology and policy language, but shaped by aristocratic prejudice and normative aims.
- C. As useless because he was biased.
- D. As the only source that matters.

Answer: B.

Explanation: Good answers use Barani critically, not blindly.

Broad MCQ 29

Question: Why are coins valuable in Topic 07?

- A. They show that all provinces used one fixed economy at all times.
- B. They reveal precise peasant income.
- C. They connect sovereignty, minting, monetisation and public claims without proving complete territorial control.
- D. They replace the need for all written sources.

Answer: C.

Explanation: Coins are strong but bounded evidence.

Broad MCQ 30

Question: Which statement about qanungo is safest?

- A. It is the normal office for every Mamluk village.
- B. It replaced the kotwal.
- C. It was another name for the ariz.
- D. Use the term only with chronology caution; it is not a secure universal office for the early Sultanate local hierarchy.

Answer: D.

Explanation: Administrative vocabulary must be time-bound.

Broad MCQ 31

Question: What best captures Lodi politics from a Topic 07 perspective?

- A. Afghan claims of consultation and equality complicated but did not abolish monarchy or centralisation.
- B. The Lodis ruled only through Sufi shrines.
- C. The Lodis rejected all revenue supervision.
- D. The Lodis ended all iqta-like assignment structures overnight.

Answer: A.

Explanation: The Afghan angle is about elite bargaining, not statelessness.

Broad MCQ 32

Question: What is the safest one-line verdict on Sultanate society?

- A. It was a static Hindu-Muslim binary with no shared spaces.
- B. It was stratified, interactive and changing - never socially flat, never wholly segregated, never fully equal.
- C. It can be reconstructed perfectly from one chronicle.
- D. It was a casteless commercial utopia.

Answer: B.

Explanation: This verdict is short, balanced and high-yield.

Remedial trap MCQs

Rotation check rule: This remedial sequence restarts at **A** and rotates strictly through **B, C and D**.

Remedial MCQ 01

Question: Which mistake most distorts Topic 07?

- A. Noting that departmental functions evolved.
- B. Using chronology caution in local vocabulary.
- C. Treating one ruler's office-chart as the permanent bureaucracy of the whole Sultanate.

- D. Separating caliphal idiom from effective sovereignty.

Answer: C.

Explanation: The topic demands variation across Mamluk, Khalji, Tughlaq and Lodi phases.

Remedial MCQ 02

Question: Which description of iqta is wrong?

- A. A service-linked assignment.
- B. A mechanism that tied revenue to military obligation.
- C. A tract whose holder could be transferred.
- D. A permanent private estate freely inheritable without superior state claim.

Answer: D.

Explanation: This is the core remedial distinction.

Remedial MCQ 03

Question: What is the safest comparison with the Mughal jagir?

- A. There is family resemblance in transferable revenue assignment, but no full equivalence in procedure, service scale or chronology.
- B. Iqta had no link at all to military service.
- C. Jagir existed unchanged before the Sultanate.
- D. Iqta and jagir were identical in every respect.

Answer: A.

Explanation: Comparison helps only when differences are preserved.

Remedial MCQ 04

Question: Which statement is unsafe on state and religion?

- A. Sharia mattered to legitimation and some offices.
- B. The Sultanate can be labelled simply a timeless theocracy without discussing zawabit, expediency or political limits.
- C. Ulema-state relations varied by ruler.
- D. Rulers also issued state regulations.

Answer: B.

Explanation: The strongest answer refuses one-word labels.

Remedial MCQ 05

Question: What is the correct approach to conversion?

- A. Explain everything through force alone.
- B. Assume every region changed identically.
- C. Reject one-cause narratives and map multiple local processes.
- D. Explain everything through saintly preaching alone.

Answer: C.

Explanation: This is a recurring UPSC trap in medieval history.

Remedial MCQ 06

Question: Which statement about social categories is safest?

- A. They erase ethnic and occupational differences.
- B. They can replace all local evidence.
- C. They are timeless democratic self-descriptions.
- D. Terms like ashraf and ajlaf are useful only with chronology, source and status caution.

Answer: D.

Explanation: Never force later or broader categories as rigid census blocks.

Remedial MCQ 07

Question: How should technology transfer be framed?

- A. As diffusion and adaptation through local artisans, state demand and regional conditions - not as one-way civilising import.
- B. As a topic unrelated to society.
- C. As proof that Indians had no prior craft skill.
- D. As immediate uniform adoption everywhere.

Answer: A.

Explanation: UPSC prefers mechanism and adaptation over civilisational cliché.

Remedial MCQ 08

Question: What is wrong with describing towns as only military camps?

- A. It notes court demand in urban growth.
- B. It ignores textile production, merchant finance, administrative clerks, religious institutions and regional trade.
- C. It links towns to roads and sarais.
- D. It recognises that some towns began near garrisons.

Answer: B.

Explanation: Many towns were mixed military, administrative and commercial spaces.

Remedial MCQ 09

Question: What is the safest reading of slavery?

- A. Slavery ended after the Mamluks.
- B. Slavery was socially harmless because masters fed slaves.
- C. Multiple forms existed, and slavery depressed free labour status even when some elite slaves rose high.
- D. Only military slavery mattered.

Answer: C.

Explanation: This restores social history to the institution.

Remedial MCQ 10

Question: Which statement about Hindus under the Sultanate is most misleading?

- A. Conflict and accommodation coexisted.
- B. Local machinery often remained in Hindu hands.
- C. Upper-caste restrictions also shaped interaction.
- D. That they were uniformly excluded from administration, trade and military activity.

Answer: D.

Explanation: The simplest exclusion formula is historically unsafe.

Remedial MCQ 11

Question: How should under-80-word evidence boxes in answers be handled?

- A. Use them as concise synthesis only when anchored in a larger argument with named evidence.
- B. Avoid evidence because it complicates the narrative.
- C. Write only verdicts and no mechanism.
- D. Replace the whole answer with one slogan.

Answer: A.

Explanation: This reinforces answer architecture discipline.

Remedial MCQ 12

Question: Which closing judgement is best?

- A. It can be summarised entirely by one tax term.
- B. The Sultanate combined centralising aspiration, negotiated enforcement and socially uneven outcomes.
- C. It was fully modern or fully feudal with no middle ground.
- D. It changed nothing socially or economically.

Answer: B.

Explanation: This sentence recovers the whole topic in one line.

PYQS AND ANSWER PRACTICE

Verified and honestly-adjacent PYQs

PYQ 01 - UPSC Prelims GS-I 2019 (directly relevant; exact wording verified locally)

Question: Consider the following statements:

1. In the revenue administration of Delhi Sultanate, the in-charge of revenue collection was known as "Amil".
2. The Iqta system of Sultans of Delhi was an ancient indigenous institution.
3. The office of "Mir Bakshi" came into existence during the reign of Khalji Sultans of Delhi.

Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

A. 1 only B. 1 and 2 only C. 3 only D. 1, 2 and 3

Inferred answer - not officially verified locally: 1 only. Confidence: high.

Model explanation: Statement 1 is correct because *amil* was the revenue-collection functionary at the relevant level. Statement 2 is incorrect because iqta had West and Central Asian antecedents before its Indian adaptation. Statement 3 is incorrect because *Mir Bakshi* belongs to the Mughal system; the Sultanate military department centred on the ariz and Diwan-i-Arz.

Why this earns marks: It tests statement-by-statement institutional placement and blocks both the indigenous-iqta myth and the Mughal-office projection trap.

Demand decoding: Treat "Consider the following statements: 1. In the revenue administration of Delhi Sultanate, the..." as a source-and-elimination problem: verify each statement independently, preserve the official wording where available, and separate an inferred key from an official key.

Detailed examiner-grade model status: The solved analysis above is the executable content base. Preserve its named evidence, causal logic, counterpoint and qualification rather than replacing it with a generic narrative.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: Identify the tested chronology, site, text, inscription or institution; eliminate each option with one named fact; then state the evidence limit or key-verification status.

How to improve this answer: For "Consider the following statements: 1. In the revenue administration of Delhi Sultanate, the...", add one explicit sentence explaining why the closest distractor fails on chronology, geography, source class or degree of certainty.

PYQ 02 - UPSC GS-I 2020 (directly relevant source-method question; wording preserved in repository)

Question: Persian literary sources of medieval India reflect the spirit of the age. Comment. (Answer in 250 words)

Model answer:

Persian literary sources are indispensable for medieval India because they preserve the language of sovereignty, conquest, justice, bureaucracy and courtly aspiration. Yet they reflect the spirit of the age only when read through **genre, patronage and silence**.

For Topic 07 this is especially clear. Barani helps explain kingship, aristocratic prejudice, Alauddin's market measures and the tension between sharia and political expediency, but he is late, moralising and hostile to low-born advancement. Ibn Battuta illuminates roads, towns, gifts, punishments and products, yet his traveller's eye seeks the vivid rather than the statistically ordinary. Afif and Firuz's own *Futuhat* reveal how a ruler wished benevolence and piety to be seen. Coins, inscriptions and buildings in turn provide harder public claims, but not full social life.

Thus Persian sources do reflect the age - especially its elite political culture, administrative ambition and moral vocabulary - but not as neutral mirrors. They require comparison with material evidence, local structures and non-courtly social realities.

Why this earns marks: It comments on the word 'reflect' itself, names multiple source types and turns source bias into method rather than complaint.

Demand decoding: The directive **comment** requires a direct position on "Persian literary sources of medieval India reflect the spirit of the age. Comment. (Answer...)"; coverage of every clause, evidence-led analysis and a qualified verdict.

Detailed examiner-grade model status: The solved analysis above is the executable content base. Preserve its named evidence, causal logic, counterpoint and qualification rather than replacing it with a generic narrative.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For a 15-mark answer, open with a two-sentence thesis; organise five named evidence units as claim -> evidence -> inference -> qualification; reserve the final lines for a graded conclusion.

How to improve this answer: For "Persian literary sources of medieval India reflect the spirit of the age. Comment. (Answer...)", replace the weakest generalisation with one additional named site, text, inscription, coin, ruler or scholarly position and state exactly what that evidence cannot prove.

PYQ 03 - UPSC Prelims GS-I 2022 (adjacent but useful frontier-institution question; exact wording verified locally)

Question: With reference to Indian history, consider the following statements:

1. The first Mongol invasion of India happened during the reign of Jalal-ud-din Khalji.
2. During the reign of Ala-ud-din Khalji, one Mongol assault marched up to Delhi and besieged the city.
3. Muhammad-bin-Tughlaq temporarily lost portions of north-west of his kingdom to Mongols.

Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

(a) 1 and 2 (b) 2 only (c) 1 and 3 (d) 3 only

Inferred answer - not officially verified locally: 2 only. Confidence: high.

Model explanation: Statement 1 is incorrect because Mongol pressure predates Jalaluddin Khalji. Statement 2 is correct because a major Mongol assault reached and besieged Delhi in Alauddin's time. Statement 3 is not secure in the form stated.

Why this earns marks: It is adjacent rather than core, but it sharpens the army-frontier chronology that any Topic 07 answer on cavalry finance and defence must keep straight.

Demand decoding: Treat "With reference to Indian history, consider the following statements: 1. The first Mongol..." as a source-and-elimination problem: verify each statement independently, preserve the official wording where available, and separate an inferred key from an official key.

Detailed examiner-grade model status: The solved analysis above is the executable content base. Preserve its named evidence, causal logic, counterpoint and qualification rather than replacing it with a generic narrative.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: Identify the tested chronology, site, text, inscription or institution; eliminate each option with one named fact; then state the evidence limit or key-verification status.

How to improve this answer: For "With reference to Indian history, consider the following statements: 1. The first Mongol...", add one explicit sentence explaining why the closest distractor fails on chronology, geography, source class or degree of certainty.

PYQ 04 - UPSC GS-I 2023 (directly relevant; wording preserved in repository)

Question: What were the major technological changes introduced during the Sultanate period? How did those technological changes influence the Indian society? (Answer in 250 words)

Model answer:

The Sultanate period witnessed important technological diffusion in textiles, record-keeping, irrigation, construction and military equipment. Their significance lay less in isolated invention than in **how they reshaped production, urban growth and state capacity**.

Paper-making widened the practical world of accounts, letters and manuscripts. The spinning wheel, cotton-carder's bow and improved looms strengthened textile production. Water-lifting devices and, in some regions, canal networks supported cultivation. Lime mortar, arches and domes enlarged the scale and durability of construction. Saddles, armour, stirrups and horse-management techniques mattered to cavalry warfare.

Social effect was uneven. Urban workshops, state offices, merchants and military systems benefited most. Artisans found new demand, but hierarchy persisted and slavery or low-wage labour remained embedded in production. Irrigation and construction enhanced elite and state power more than universal welfare.

Thus technological change under the Sultanate contributed to urbanisation, stronger administration, wider textile production and military organisation, while remaining filtered through social inequality.

Why this earns marks: It answers both parts, moves from devices to effects and avoids the trap of a bare technology list.

Demand decoding: The directive **answer** requires a direct position on "What were the major technological changes introduced during the Sultanate period? How did...", coverage of every clause, evidence-led analysis and a qualified verdict.

Detailed examiner-grade model status: The solved analysis above is the executable content base. Preserve its named evidence, causal logic, counterpoint and qualification rather than replacing it with a generic narrative.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For a 15-mark answer, open with a two-sentence thesis; organise five named evidence units as claim -> evidence -> inference -> qualification; reserve the final lines for a graded conclusion.

How to improve this answer: For “What were the major technological changes introduced during the Sultanate period? How did...”, replace the weakest generalisation with one additional named site, text, inscription, coin, ruler or scholarly position and state exactly what that evidence cannot prove.

PYQ verification ledger and scope honesty

- **Directly verified and solved:** 2019 Prelims GS-I revenue administration; 2020 GS-I Persian literary sources; 2023 GS-I Sultanate technology.
- **Directly verified but honestly adjacent:** 2022 Prelims GS-I Mongol chronology question.
- **Routed but exact wording not locally recoverable in the available paper set:** 2022 Prelims GS-I Q52 on *fanam* medieval monetary terminology. Topic 07 covers the demand honestly in the learning sections and in the register notes, but does not invent an unverified official stem.
- No coaching-studio question and no optional-paper question has been relabelled as a UPSC PYQ.

Original solved Mains questions

Mains 01 - 10 marks

Question: Explain why the Delhi Sultanate is best described as a centralised apex resting on negotiated local power. Answer in 150 words.

Model answer:

The Delhi Sultanate built a visible central apex: the sultan distributed office and iqta, commanded the army, issued coinage, controlled chancery communication and projected justice. Departments such as the Wizarat, Arz and Insha show that rule had differentiated institutional form. Coins, khutba and court ceremonial further publicised sovereignty.

Yet this apex never operated in a social vacuum. Muqtis, amils, khuts, muqaddams, chaudhuris, patwaris, chiefs and merchants translated central claims into actual grain, cash, horses and obedience. Village structures were not erased; they were used. Even when Alauddin tightened khalisa control, he did not abolish local intermediaries. Firuz later softened audit and hereditary claims widened.

Thus the best formulation is that the Sultanate was centralised in aspiration and more centralised than many earlier regional monarchies, but it remained negotiated in implementation. Distance, ecology, faction and local landed strength limited uniform bureaucratic control.

Why this earns marks: It opens with a direct thesis, names institutions, explains the local mechanism, adds dynastic variation and ends with a balanced verdict.

Demand decoding: The directive **explain** requires a direct position on “Explain why the Delhi Sultanate is best described as a centralised apex resting on...”, coverage of every clause, evidence-led analysis and a qualified verdict.

Detailed examiner-grade model status: The solved analysis above is the executable content base. Preserve its named evidence, causal logic, counterpoint and qualification rather than replacing it with a generic narrative.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For a 10-mark answer, open with a two-sentence thesis; organise three named evidence units as claim -> evidence -> inference -> qualification; reserve the final lines for a graded conclusion.

How to improve this answer: For “Explain why the Delhi Sultanate is best described as a centralised apex resting on...”, replace the weakest generalisation with one additional named site, text, inscription, coin, ruler or scholarly position and state exactly what that evidence cannot prove.

Mains 02 - 10 marks

Question: How did the iqta system function, and why should it not be equated with private property? Answer in 150 words.

Model answer:

The iqta was a fiscal-military assignment through which the sultan transferred the right to collect revenue from a tract to a muqti or wali in return for service, administration and troop maintenance. The holder preserved order, met authorised expenses and, in principle, remained accountable for the balance due to the centre. Transfer, recall and audit were the key checks.

It should not be treated as private property because legal superiority remained with the state. The muqti did not own the soil, all peasants, or an automatically hereditary estate. Procedures differed across time: Mamluk rulers used iqta for consolidation, Alauddin tightened supervision in the core, Muhammad bin Tughlaq experimented with cash and revenue farming, and Firuz encouraged heredity and softer audit.

Therefore the iqta was a service-linked revenue assignment whose meaning changed with political strength. Calling it simple property, or equating it mechanically with European feudalism or Mughal jagir, obscures its historical function.

Why this earns marks: It defines the institution, shows mechanism, inserts chronology and blocks the standard property trap.

Demand decoding: The directive **answer** requires a direct position on “How did the iqta system function, and why should it not be equated with private property?...”, coverage of every clause, evidence-led analysis and a qualified verdict.

Detailed examiner-grade model status: The solved analysis above is the executable content base. Preserve its named evidence, causal logic, counterpoint and qualification rather than replacing it with a generic narrative.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For a 10-mark answer, open with a two-sentence thesis; organise three named evidence units as claim -> evidence -> inference -> qualification; reserve the final lines for a graded conclusion.

How to improve this answer: For “How did the iqta system function, and why should it not be equated with private property?...”, replace the weakest generalisation with one additional named site, text, inscription, coin, ruler or scholarly position and state exactly what that evidence cannot prove.

Mains 03 - 15 marks

Question: Examine the relationship between monetisation, urbanisation and agrarian extraction under the Delhi Sultanate. Answer in 250 words.

Model answer:

The Delhi Sultanate's towns did not float free from the countryside. Monetisation and urbanisation expanded, but they did so through a military-fiscal system that drew agrarian surplus upward.

First, stable coinage - especially the silver tanka and copper jital - helped taxation, salary payment and market exchange. Second, a stronger central state improved roads, relays and sarais, allowing grain, cloth, horses and money to move between regions. Third, merchant finance through hundis, modis and sarrafs widened the reach of long-distance trade. Delhi, Lahore, Multan, Lakhnauti, Cambay and Sonargaon all grew through this interaction of state demand and commerce.

But the urban story cannot be separated from rural burden. Alauddin's core-zone extraction, Muhammad bin Tughlaq's harsh doab assessment and the dependence of iqta-holders on rural realisation show that towns and armies were sustained by peasant production. Khuts, muqaddams and chiefs mediated this transfer and often protected their own position.

Hence growth and coercion must be read together. Urban revival was real - textiles, paper, metallurgy and trade flourished - yet much of that revival depended on unequal surplus extraction and elite consumption.

Why this earns marks: It links coinage, roads, finance and towns to the agrarian mechanism instead of narrating them separately.

Demand decoding: The directive **examine** requires a direct position on “Examine the relationship between monetisation, urbanisation and agrarian extraction under...”, coverage of every clause, evidence-led analysis and a qualified verdict.

Detailed examiner-grade model status: The solved analysis above is the executable content base. Preserve its named evidence, causal logic, counterpoint and qualification rather than replacing it with a generic narrative.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For a 15-mark answer, open with a two-sentence thesis; organise five named evidence units as claim -> evidence -> inference -> qualification; reserve the final lines for a graded conclusion.

How to improve this answer: For “Examine the relationship between monetisation, urbanisation and agrarian extraction under...”, replace the weakest generalisation with one additional named site, text, inscription, coin, ruler or scholarly position and state exactly what that evidence cannot prove.

Mains 04 - 15 marks

Question: Assess the changing composition of the Sultanate nobility and its political consequences. Answer in 250 words.

Model answer:

The Sultanate nobility changed from an early concentration of Turks and military slaves to a wider, more contested elite including Persians, Khaljis, Afghans, Indian Muslims, converts and local allies. That widening mattered politically because it altered both opportunity and instability.

In the Mamluk phase, elite slavery and Turkish high-status claims gave the court a disciplined but narrow ruling circle. Barani's later contempt for low-born appointment reflects this older exclusionary ideal. Yet even early Delhi required Tajik administrators, Hindu accountants and local chiefs.

The Khalji phase widened access to office by weakening old Turkish monopoly. Alauddin's state needed talent and force more than pedigree alone. Muhammad bin Tughlaq widened recruitment further, appointing foreigners, new men and some Hindus to high office. This improved reach, but chroniclers portray intense aristocratic resentment. Firuz reversed course toward conciliation, high salaries and heredity, which reduced friction in the short run but narrowed discipline and hardened oligarchic interests. In the Lodi phase, Afghan notions of consultation complicated monarchical centralisation further.

Therefore, changing noble composition was not a background detail. It shaped succession, military command, revenue control and ideological conflict at the heart of the Sultanate.

Why this earns marks: It uses chronology, named source bias and political consequence rather than listing communities mechanically.

Demand decoding: The directive **assess** requires a direct position on “Assess the changing composition of the Sultanate nobility and its political consequences....”, coverage of every clause, evidence-led analysis and a qualified verdict.

Detailed examiner-grade model status: The solved analysis above is the executable content base. Preserve its named evidence, causal logic, counterpoint and qualification rather than replacing it with a generic narrative.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For a 15-mark answer, open with a two-sentence thesis; organise five named evidence units as claim -> evidence -> inference -> qualification; reserve the final lines for a graded conclusion.

How to improve this answer: For “Assess the changing composition of the Sultanate nobility and its political consequences....”, replace the weakest generalisation with one additional named site, text, inscription, coin, ruler or scholarly position and state exactly what that evidence cannot prove.

Mains 05 - 20 marks

Question: 'The Delhi Sultanate was neither a uniform bureaucracy nor a timeless Islamic state.' Discuss. Answer in 250 words.

Model answer:

The statement is persuasive because it rejects two misleading simplifications at once. The Delhi Sultanate did develop differentiated institutions, but these never produced a uniform modern-style bureaucracy across all regions and reigns. Likewise, Islamic language and law mattered deeply, yet the state cannot be reduced to a timeless theocracy.

On the administrative side, the Sultanate had a clear central apex: the sultan, wazir, ariz, insha, qazi-sadr and barid network. Coinage, khutba, court ceremonial and iqta transfers demonstrate organised sovereignty. Yet implementation depended on muqtis, amils, khuts, muqaddams, chaudhuris, chiefs, merchants and village accountants. Terms such as shiq, pargana and zamindar must themselves be used chronologically and regionally. Alauddin's tighter supervision, Muhammad bin Tughlaq's over-centralising experiments, Firuz's hereditary drift and Lodi Afghan bargaining show that no single administrative diagram fits the whole period.

On the religious side, rulers invoked sharia, appointed qazis and ulema, and used caliphal or juristic idiom. But political expediency repeatedly supplemented formal law. Alauddin openly asserted reason of state; Muhammad bin Tughlaq mixed symbolic caliphal legitimacy with wider intellectual contact; Firuz moved toward sharper juristic display yet still governed through public works, compromise and material calculation. Non-Muslim communities retained their own social institutions and local law in many settings.

Thus the Sultanate is best read as a Persianate military-fiscal monarchy using Islamic legitimacy while ruling through negotiated, uneven and practical governance.

Why this earns marks: It answers both negations directly, organises the body into state and religion, and ends with a precise synthetic verdict.

Demand decoding: The directive **discuss** requires a direct position on “The Delhi Sultanate was neither a uniform bureaucracy nor a timeless Islamic state.’...”, coverage of every clause, evidence-led analysis and a qualified verdict.

Detailed examiner-grade model status: The solved analysis above is the executable content base. Preserve its named evidence, causal logic, counterpoint and qualification rather than replacing it with a generic narrative.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For a 20-mark answer, open with a two-sentence thesis; organise six to eight named evidence units as claim -> evidence -> inference -> qualification; reserve the final lines for a graded conclusion.

How to improve this answer: For “The Delhi Sultanate was neither a uniform bureaucracy nor a timeless Islamic state.’...”, replace the weakest generalisation with one additional named site, text, inscription, coin, ruler or scholarly position and state exactly what that evidence cannot prove.

Mains 06 - 20 marks

Question: Evaluate the social consequences of technology diffusion, trade growth and labour hierarchy under the Delhi Sultanate. Answer in 250 words.

Model answer:

Technology diffusion and trade growth under the Delhi Sultanate reshaped production and exchange, but their social effects were filtered through hierarchy. Gains were real, yet unevenly distributed.

In production, wider use of the spinning wheel, cotton-carder's bow, improved looms, paper-making and construction techniques supported textiles, record-keeping and urban building. Water-lifting improvements and canals aided cultivation in some regions. Better roads, sarais and monetary circulation widened long-distance exchange. Merchant groups - Multanis, Gujaratis, Khurasanis, Marwaris, Jains and Bohras - worked with financiers and hundis to move goods and credit.

These processes encouraged urbanisation and specialised craft activity. Delhi, Cambay, Sonargaon and other towns became centres of demand and exchange. Court consumption, army provisioning and merchant trade stimulated artisans in both towns and villages.

Yet the social gains were not equal. Peasants still bore heavy revenue pressure. Artisans often worked for low wages or in dependent conditions. Slavery - domestic, artisanal and military - remained embedded in elite society, and the use of slaves could depress the status of free labour. Upper-status prejudice persisted among both Hindu and Muslim elites; purdah and social restriction spread most strongly among the upper classes.

Therefore technology and trade expanded capability, but they did not democratise society. They enlarged state power, urban consumption and commercial reach within a deeply stratified order.

Demand decoding: The directive **evaluate** requires a direct position on “Evaluate the social consequences of technology diffusion, trade growth and labour hierarchy...”, coverage of every clause, evidence-led analysis and a qualified verdict.

Detailed examiner-grade model status: The solved analysis above is the executable content base. Preserve its named evidence, causal logic, counterpoint and qualification rather than replacing it with a generic narrative.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For a 20-mark answer, open with a two-sentence thesis; organise six to eight named evidence units as claim -> evidence -> inference -> qualification; reserve the final lines for a graded conclusion.

Why this earns marks: The answer follows the directive, links precise evidence to analysis, acknowledges source or regional limits and closes with a reasoned verdict.

How to improve this answer: For “Evaluate the social consequences of technology diffusion, trade growth and labour hierarchy...”, replace the weakest generalisation with one additional named site, text, inscription, coin, ruler or scholarly position and state exactly what that evidence cannot prove.